Much of Strong's report is weak on detail, and given what we now know, misleading in its portrayal of White House discussions (though this may reflect that Strong was being misled – inadvertently or otherwise). Strong was a highly experienced intelligence officer who enjoyed the trust of senior officials in Washington. The President and ExComm knew he was being briefed by McCone before his return to London. It seems unlikely that the DCI exceeded his brief. So, did Kennedy want the British to believe he 'would go all the way' on Berlin (whether he intended to or not)? There is nothing in any exchanges between President and Prime Minister to support such conjecture. In short, the episode remains one of many puzzles about the crisis, and one which fails to provide a satisfactory answer to the question of whether JFK would have initiated a nuclear attack over Berlin.

Making a drama out of a crisis?

McGeorge Bundy wrote in 1988, 'We must make it our business not to pass this way again.'[11] True that. But where exactly were we in October 1962? While Nikita Khrushchev may have given metaphors a bad name, many historians have written of the world being 'on the brink'. What is clear is that the closer Kennedy and Khrushchev got to the brink, the greater their awareness of the abyss, and the more determined they were to find a diplomatic way back. Some suggest that the risk of war, and in particular, nuclear war, was exaggerated; others, that it was negligible. As the Pulitzer Prize-winning writer Max Frankel argues, 'it is clear that Khrushchev and Kennedy were effectively deterred by their fear of war and took great care to avoid even minor military clashes'.[12] A 2020 study by Theodore Voorhees reaches an even more stark conclusion: 'the Cold War environment of October 1962 proved to be a surprisingly safe period to be alive during the post-World War II era.'[13]

What was the view from the top of the cliff? On one hand, Robert McNamara recalls that, on 27 October, he worried he might never see another Saturday evening. On the other, he says that he and the President never discussed the immediate prospect of nuclear war. This accords with the recollections of General Maxwell Taylor: